

IANS

THE RACE HORSES Clockwise from left, Bhagwant Mann, Chetan Singh Jauramajra, Harmeet Singh Pathanmajra

▶ PUNJAB

AAP'S DEFENCE FIRST STRATEGY

Mann makes a move with an early and safe first list of candidates. Another first list in the poll season—of defectors—shows rationale. It's a circling of wagons herd

By **Anilesh S. Mahajan**

Takeaways

- **AAP releases a safe first list for February poll—all 40 sitting MLAs renominated**
- **Talk is that hard options have been deferred to the 77 seats that remain open**
- **Two fresh MLA defectors link up with rebel to join BJP; AAP aims to stanch exits**
- **Tickets mean incentive to stay: development funds can be spent till code comes**

THE FIRST DEFECTIONS FROM THE AAM AADMI PARTY (AAP) have come before Punjab's 2027 campaign has begun. AAP named its first 40 candidates on October 31. A day later, MLAs Harmeet Singh Pathanmajra (Sanaur) and Chetan Singh Jouramajra (Samana) quit. On November 2, both joined the BJP along with Kunwar Vijay Pratap Singh, who had resigned as Amritsar North MLA in June 2025 after being suspended for "anti-party activities". AAP will seek the disqualification of the other two. There's some justification to spokesperson Neel Garg's description of them as three "sidelined people", not leaders of stellar repute whose loss would count. But the culling of mavericks was part of the first moves for battle. Operation Fortress: a circling of wagons, a rearming of battlements.

A day before, AAP had released its first list, renominating all 40 sitting MLAs in the seats it covered, including chief minister Bhagwant Mann (Dhuri), Speaker Kultar Singh Sandhwan (Kotkapura) and minister Sanjeev Arora (Ludhiana West), who's been in Enforcement Directorate custody since May. Speculation that 30 to 35 MLAs may be dropped has not been borne out yet; insiders say the hard choices stand deferred to the 77 seats that remain open. Consolidating and protecting the flanks is the imperative—this is not the time to court rebellion. State party chief Aman Arora and finance minister Harpal Singh Cheema have yet to be assigned seats. Constituency in-charges have also been named for 19 seats, seven held by its own MLAs, including Sanaur and Samana.

RISK MANAGEMENT

The 2024 Lok Sabha results show the risk AAP is trying to cover with insurance. In 2022, it had won 92 seats with 42.01 per cent of the vote, 19 points ahead of the Congress. But in 2024, it led in only 33 assembly segments; Congress led in 37, BJP in 23, Independents in 15 and the Akalis in nine. Eight ministers trailed in their own segments. The Congress, in fact, polled 26.3 per cent votes to AAP's 26.0. Four ministers, Jouramajra among them, were dropped in the reshuffle that followed.

Since then, AAP has won six of seven assembly byelections, including the panthic-oriented Tarn Taran by 12,091 votes. It also won 218 of 347 zila parishad zones last December—a result the Congress disputes—and 958 of 1,977 municipal wards this May, against Congress's 397.

So, how is this asymmetry to be interpreted? "The assessment will have to be constituency-specific," says Ashutosh Kumar, who teaches political science at Panjab University, Chandigarh. "In some seats, a new candidate may be necessary." The defections cap a difficult year. On April 24, seven of AAP's 10 Rajya Sabha MPs, six from Punjab and led by Raghav Chadha, merged with the